

Regular Meeting
May 1, 2017
School Committee Meeting
Council Chambers

The regular meeting of the Medford School Committee was called to order by Mayor Burke in the City Hall Council Chambers at 7:18 p.m. Those present were Ms.Cugno, Ms. DiBenedetto, Ms. Kreatz, Ms. Mustone, Mr. Skerry, Ms. Van der Kloot, Mayor Burke and Superintendent Belson.

On the motion of Ms. Cugno seconded by Mr. Skerry that the amended minutes of April 3, 2017

be approved:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Cugno that the minutes of April 24, 2017 be approved:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto that the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved:

Voted: That the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot that the Payrolls be approved:

Voted: That the Payrolls be approved

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

Report on Connors Scholarship

Superintendent Belson reported that this year a substantial new scholarship program is in place for Medford student. The scholarship fund will award up to fifty (50) scholarships in the amount of three thousand dollars (\$3000) each to successful applicants.

High school students who live in Medford and attend public, private, and/or charter schools are eligible. Students who attain a minimum of a 2.3 grade point average can

qualify. This is in keeping with the desire of the Connors family to help the average student have a “shot” of attending college. The trustees of the scholarship are John Granara Jr. Esquire; former Mayor Michael J. McGlynn and Stephen Andrew. The fund is administered through Scholarship America. The Medford High School Guidance Department is actively working with our students to complete applications for the scholarship. James and Thelma Connors were individuals who lived a modest life but believed strongly in helping others. Their story is attached to this report. We are very grateful to Jim and Thelma for their generosity and to the trustees who developed this plan to help the students of Medford. Director of Guidance Amelia Jensen spoke briefly about the scholarship application process.

Discussion:

Ms. Van der Kloot commented that this is such a wonderful thing for our students; it is a dream come true. She requested a list of recipients when selected. Ms. DiBenedetto thanked Ms. Jensen and her office staff for assisting the students with the application. Ms. Jensen said that the scholarship looks not only at grades and leadership but also work experience and hardships. Ms. Kreatz also thanked the guidance department and said it is a wonderful opportunity for our students. Ms. Cugno hopes the students understand the generosity and incredible story of Mr. and Mrs. Connors.

On the motion of Ms. Cugno seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot to accept the report and place on file:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Report on Class of 2017 College/University Acceptances

Director of Guidance Amelia Jensen presented the report. Ms. Jensen stated that Students are still updating us on their acceptances and making decisions on where they will attend (final updates are due 5/11). However, so far, about 220 students have reported being accepted to over 225 different colleges and universities. Some of these notable schools include Brown University, Duke University, Harvard University, Tufts University, Wellesley College, Yale University, UMASS (all schools), UNH, UVM, URI, and many state schools. Many students this year received scholarships and awards: National Merit Finalist, Posse Scholarship Winner (full ride scholarship to Bucknell University), Full ride soccer scholarship to Duke University, and Full ride scholarship to Tufts University. Two MVTHS students are in apprenticeship programs at night to become plumbers, which is a year ahead of other students in their education and training. This was also the first year that 35+ students have chosen alternative post-secondary paths through work programs that lead to bachelor degrees, many of them are completely paid for (Rockland Earn & Learn, Year Up, and Match Beyond). An updated acceptance and attendance list will be generated in May and will be placed on this year’s graduation booklet again.

Discussion:

Ms. Cugno said she is extremely proud of our students and wants to make sure that this information is included in the graduation booklet. She said many students get accepted to great schools but because of the finances sometimes don't attend. Ms. DiBenedetto asked how many students have been accepted to Tufts. Mayor Burke answered 7 have been accepted to date with multiple students on the wait list.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Cugno to accept the report and place on file:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Report on Opioid Prevention Grant

Superintendent Belson introduced Supervisors Toni Vento and Rachel Perry to present the report. Ms. Vento reported that Maura Healey, Massachusetts Attorney General, utilized over \$500,000 from a settlement with CVS and Walgreen pharmacies to fund the Youth Opioid Prevention Grant Program. This program was designed to support school-based prevention education initiatives that address opioid dependence and addiction. Funds were awarded to districts who planned to implement a sustainable prevention curriculum. We are proud to announce that our district is a recipient of an \$18,000 award to implement a sustainable substance abuse prevention curriculum. In our schools, we have initiated many multidisciplinary programs to address the social-emotional needs of our students with the goal of preventing the development of addictive behaviors. These programs include: student athlete and parent drug/alcohol awareness education, parent forums by speakers such as Chris Herron and Dr. Ruth Potee, SBIRT screening, Narcan and DiTep training of nurses, partnership with Team Medford and the Medford Board of Health for youth risk surveys, district professional development about social-emotional learning, purchase of Michigan Model curriculum and partnership with Safe Project. Project Goals, Objectives and Outcomes:

- Purchasing more Michigan Model health education curriculum to provide one kit to each elementary and middle school teacher. We presently have kits at each grade level that are shared by teachers. By purchasing more kits we will allow teachers more opportunities to present Michigan Model lessons to students.
- Providing a yearly parent education forum about substance use and prevention. Drug prevention efforts will include teaching parents the signs of drug use, drug & alcohol trends and provide community resources.
- Providing faculty training on identification of substance use, risky behaviors and preventative strategies. It is important for faculty to be able to identify substance use and to take the proper steps to assist students needing help.
- Increasing community awareness of resources for education and student support. Supplying resources for education and student support will allow everyone in the community to access information as needed.
- Strengthening partnerships with community organizations to reinforce school health education. We will work with outside community organizations to promote skills taught in the Michigan Model health curriculum.

Our predicted outcomes with this grant funding include:

- Improved Communities That Care Survey data, we expect drug use to decrease and protective factors to increase.
- The Michigan Model curriculum will be delivered to more children in the Medford community by presenting Michigan Model skills to community groups.
- We expect an increase in parent knowledge and involvement since we will be presenting parent forums and resources.

We will measure the success of the program by:

- Assessing community that cares surveys. We will assess the 2017 survey and make comparisons to the 2019 survey.
- Providing and assessing program surveys. We will assess all of the surveys given during the program and take feedback to make changes.
- We will use the pre and post assessments for Michigan Model lessons to measure student learning of the Michigan Model curriculum health skills.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto thanked all involved stating that \$18,000 for drug prevention is great. She asked if they worked at all with Penny Funaiolo. Ms. Vento replied that they worked with Penny on the grant. They also funded a parent forum a couple of weeks ago. Ms. DiBenedetto suggested reaching out to *Medford Against Addiction* and to the parents to get their perspective. Get all the ideas and outreach as possible. Ms. DiBenedetto asked if there are any new mandates from the state regarding drugs? Superintendent Belson said not yet but will probably see them at budget time. Ms. DiBenedetto replied that if we get mandates from DESE or the state they we require them to fund them. Ms. Van der Kloot mentioned that she and Ms. Kreatz attended the recent talk on drugs and said it was the best one she has ever attended. Ms. Kreatz agreed and said that more parent forums should be held. Ms. Cugno asked if they ever attend the monthly meeting with the Council and the police. Ms. Vento answered no but they did a presentation recently at the council meeting. Ms. Cugno suggested going to let them know what is being done and to get the word out.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto seconded by Ms. Kreatz to accept the report and place on file:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Recommendation to Approve School Committee Meeting Schedule School Year 2017-2018

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Mustone to approve the School Committee calendar for SY 2017-2018

Vote:

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

Nay: 0
Absent: 0

Recommendation to Reject School Choice School Year 2017-2018

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot seconded by Ms. Cugno to reject school choice for SY 2017-2018

Vote:

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

Report on TecEdge Technology Study

Superintendent Belson reported that attached is the TecEdge reports on our technology networks and infrastructure. We commissioned this report to provide us with guidance on the best pathways to improve and strengthen our capacities to use technology effectively. Also to enable us to access E-Rate Tier 2 funding in support of upgrades. These reports are very technical and extensive. They are provided to you so that you can more fully appreciate the complexity of integrating technology into our programs at the public schools. The recommendations provide specific guidance to us. Several steps can be taken without any burdensome cost. Still, it is important for us to recognize that the heavy requirements of testing, state reporting, electronic data management and communication requires that we have a finely tuned robust and reliable capacity to meet our obligations. This is not a one time need. However, many of the upgrades will enable us to go forward for several years. This is a very good investment. The Superintendent recommends that you read the executive summary of each report as a way to become familiar and to avoid the heavy technical backup that will be used by our network engineers to implement upgrades. Additionally, you will find our category 2 E-Rate funding estimates. Under this program we can access \$398,100 of federal funds with a \$265,400 match. We are currently soliciting bids and completing E-Rate applications. We will seek capital funding for our match which would be paid out in FY 2018. Our plan will be to upgrade all wireless systemwide and replace switches in the high school and middle schools. We must act this year because there is no guarantee that E-Rate Tier2 funding will survive federal budget cuts going forward. Also we are now preparing a listing of technology devices that can access the system and will be necessary to support students, faculty and administrative staff. Some of these devices will be budget and some will be capital.

Discussion:

Ms. Van der Kloot said that she reviewed the report in detail. It was very comprehensive and made sense. She asked if the committee should have a Committee of the Whole to review. Superintendent Belson answered that we need to move forward with the application process. Ms. Van der Kloot said she is ready to authorize and move forward. Ms. DiBenedetto asked if we move forward don't we need \$265,000 match and if so is this a line item budgeted because we need a commitment for technology every year. Director of Finance Kirsteen Patterson gave an overview of the financial planning and the process moving forward. Superintendent Belson said that they need to apply by May 11th. Ms. Mustone questioned the drastic difference in device numbers at the schools.

Ms. Patterson answered that the chart only reflects one day. Ms. Mustone commented that it seems like a large disparity and asked if anyone else is shocked. Superintendent Belson said that we can get a comment from the technology department.

On the motion of Ms. Cugno seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto to submit a formal application to the federal government:

Vote:

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

Nay: 0

Absent: 0

Pre Budget – Buildings and Grounds

Superintendent Belson stated that in FY 2018 he plans to recommend an additional \$200,000 be added to our building repairs budget for general maintenance and upgrades at each of our buildings. Also we will begin to advance our capital plan for any major upgrades. It should be remembered that we have submitted a Statement of Interest to MSBA for the high school. We hope to meet with them in the near future to ascertain our possibilities for state funding. Director of Building and Grounds John McLaughlin continued with his report. He explained the various projects done this year and the continuation of projects moving forward into the summer months. He discussed staffing issues and his requests for next year which include an additional carpenter.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto asked if the \$200,000 is going to be an annual increase. Superintendent Belson answered that he doesn't know if we will have funding but would like to see it grow every year because it would give us much more flexibility. Ms. Mustone thanked the parents at the Brooks for the ideas on improvements. She also asked about the Community Schools entrance. Mr. McLaughlin said that they are in hopes that the vocational students will set up the scaffolding so we can fix the fan and paint etc. Ms. Cugno asked for clarification on the pool door. Mr. McLaughlin said it is Door 31. Ms. Cugno asked Mr. McLaughlin if he has a wish list of things that need to be done. He answered that he would like to have the bleachers repaired this summer. Ms. Cugno asked if the bathrooms and playgrounds are on the list. He said that they are on the capital plan along with repairing parking lots. Ms. DiBenedetto thanked Mr. McLaughlin and Alicia Hunt for getting the lighting improved at the Curtis/Tufts. She also reminded Mr. McLaughlin to finish the painting and stripping the floors. She supports the request for an additional carpenter. Mr. Skerry asked if there is any chance on getting auto body on list to paint their ceiling before the floor is done. Mr. McLaughlin said that he will look into it that it probably needs to be sprayed so he will get a price. Ms. Van der Kloot asked where we are with the capital plan. Mayor Burke answered that the city side is almost nailed down and another Committee of the Whole is needed for the school side. Ms. Van der Kloot commented that the playgrounds still need to be looked at.

Report on State Proposed Budget FY 2018

Superintendent Belson presented the report. He stated that the Massachusetts House of Representatives passed its initial version of the FY 2018 state budget on Tuesday, April 25, 2017. The House version will now go to the state Senate for their deliberations. We should expect a Senate version to emerge in late May. Since there will be differences between the two legislative bodies, there will be a joint conference committee consisting of three members from each chamber to resolve each item. When the conference committee completes its work the unified conference reconciliation will go to the full body in each chamber for a yes/no vote. No changes are allowed. When passed it will go to the Governor who may veto items. The Legislature can accept the Governor's actions or override the vetoes with a two-thirds majority required in each chamber. It is likely that the Legislature will override most vetoes. It is expected, although not certain, that the state budget will be completed by the end of the current fiscal year in late June. Since our school and city must also complete an FY 2018 fiscal budget by June 30, 2017, we will have to work with the estimates we can glean from the legislative versions as they emerge in late May. It would be rare for the final state budget to be less than the House version. The Senate tends to be more financially generous than the House although line items may vary. For the first time the initial budget bottom line number is over forty billion dollars. The House summarily considered 1210 amendments by consolidating them into 30 roll call votes. It was a quick floor process that added \$77.7 million to the House Ways and Means recommendation. Most of the additions were from local earmarks. The House floor budget virtually mirrored the House Ways and Means version. The main limitation on the budget is the anticipated availability of money to support the various line items and any new program/services. Most of the new money goes for the funding of Mass Health, pensions, and a modest increase in local aid. During FY 2016 the state found that the budget was initially short \$455 million. This year (FY 2017) revenue is running \$220 million below estimates through March. April receipts are expected to be strong but there is no guarantee that the amount collected will be able to close the gap. Originally, there was a projection of 3.1% growth but the current through March is 1.7%. A study by the Federal Reserve explained that while Massachusetts unemployment was down, there was a significant drop in wages and hours worked. This means that overall personal income was lower. Also spending was higher, most notably in the health sector. Additionally, sales tax on merchandise was affected by increased online buying. Furthermore, it is possible that the income tax rate will drop again because of the automatic trigger built into the rules. There appears to be no appetite for increased taxation although there may be a proposal out of the Senate. Lastly, we can expect some cutbacks from Washington on domestic spending including various education items.

The following items are specific to the House Education budget and Medford:

- Chapter 70 is up \$30 per pupil or approximately \$145,410. Unrestricted municipal aid was up \$40 million statewide.
- The Special Education Circuit Breaker was level funded. It could be short between \$10 and \$15 million for full funding. As more students qualify there is greater demand on this account. We are projecting less funding in FY 2017 than FY 2016. There could be a further reduction in FY 2018.

- Charter School funding is level funded. We expect the statewide entitlement to be \$60 million plus below need. Depending on the number of students who opt for charter schools. We could see an increase in local cost. We are also looking at Washington to determine if there will be new mandates from that source.
- Homeless transportation is level funded (50% or less)
- No funding for kindergarten
- Out of District Non-Resident transportation is cut. Could lose about \$30,000.
- There is no new funding for technology. We will be able to get significant new federal dollars. (see report)
- The DPH health funding should be reasonably stable.
- Early Childhood funding though the grant account is expected to lose 30% of current level as priorities shift from programs to workforce development support.

We are awaiting final distribution numbers from the state and DESE but the initial outlook is not robust which means that we are more dependent upon local appropriation and revenue generation. We will keep you posted.

Discussion:

Ms. Mustone questioned who does the out of district transportation affect. Superintendent Belson answered the Minuteman students. Next year there will only be 8 students so we are trying to get a small bus to do the run. Ms. Van der Kloot commented on the National School Board's announcement regarding Medicaid reimbursements and mentioning that this could be another area where we lose monies. Superintendent Belson replied that Medicaid funding comes to students with disabilities and the monies are factored into the whole pot. Ms. DiBenedetto said that this includes speech, physical and occupational therapies for students who need these services. Treat right and treat early and won't need it later.

On the motion of Ms. Mustone seconded by Ms. Kreatz the report was accepted and placed on file.

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

New Business

School Committee Resolution

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Irene Haggie. Mrs. Haggie was the mother of Carolyn Haggie former Administrative Assistant to the Superintendent and Secretary to the School Committee.

School Committee Resolutions:

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Ahmet Azizi. Mr. Azizi was a former Medford Public Schools custodian.

A moment of silence was held.

Ms. Van der Kloot asked for authorization for Mr. Skerry to sign the bills next week as she has a conflict.

Vote:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot the meeting was adjourned at 8:39 p.m.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

Nay: 0

Absent: 0

Respectfully submitted:

Paulette Van der Kloot
Secretary

